

hack into the systems of the companies in question. Most businesses store their sensitive information on servers and the data may or may not be financial in nature. Hackers who can gain access into the systems of these companies get access to all the information available in these files. They can choose to destroy or leak them, or where money is concerned transfer funds from an organization to someone else's account. That's not the only downside to being hacked. The customers of that particular company lose faith in the organization such cases and thus, businesses



Hackers can operate from anywhere

can lose a significant number of customers based on incidents such as these. Also, the time spent by the IT professionals of the companies in trying to avoid these situations could instead be used for more productive purposes. Thus, even the threat of cyber crime can result in lower pro-

ductivity levels. When a business's website is hacked, it tends to lose traffic which translates into loss of revenue for the unfortunate company.

- ▶ **Cyber crime against governments:** Cyber criminals can attack organizations of any kind and government organizations are not an exception. The secure database of a government agency can be hacked with the intention to misuse sensitive information and the term “cyber-terrorism” is often used in this context. The term is defined by the FBI as “the pre-meditated, politically motivated attack against information, computer systems, computer programs and data which results in violence against non-combatant targets by sub-national groups or clandestine agents”. Basically, any individual or group gaining access to any sensitive information pertaining to the government and using it to cause disharmony, are cyber-terrorists. Strong political agenda might also be behind these cyber attacks against the government. Cyber crime could be used to undermine the effectiveness of a government, thus reducing the faith of citizens in a particular government.

Another form of cyber attack against the government is “hacktivism”. It is a somewhat recent development, and is basically activism in the cyber